

frAGILE™

THE DICTIONARY

100 corporate terms, translated into the language of organizational survival.

A satirical field guide to the gap between how organizations say they work and how they actually work.

Publication edition. No narration cues, no pauses, no action items. These definitions caricature organizational habits, not every person working inside them.

NO FOLLOW-UP REQUIRED.

001. Actionable Insights

Raw data tweaked and tortured until it agrees with the decision leadership already made.

002. Agile

A flexible way of working, commonly implemented as a rigid calendar of ceremonies for discussing why the flexible work cannot change.

003. Alignment

The thirty-second period when everyone agrees on a direction before returning to their departments with five different interpretations of it.

004. Architecture

The structural foundation expected to survive every new strategy while remaining firmly outside this quarter's scope.

005. Artifact

A document created to prove that a conversation happened, usually moments before another meeting is scheduled to discuss the document.

006. Asynchronous (Async)

A communication method designed to let people respond on their own schedule, followed approximately eleven minutes later by, "Just checking if you saw this."

007. Backlog

A digital graveyard of low-priority bug reports, minor feature requests, and abandoned dreams that no sprint will ever touch.

008. Bake-off

Two teams asked to prove which approach is better, usually after the preferred approach has already appeared in the executive deck.

009. Bandwidth

Your remaining mental capacity to tolerate another meeting that could have been a three-sentence email.

010. Benchmark

Studying competitors to understand the market, shortly before rebuilding the exact feature everyone agreed was mediocre.

011. Bespoke

A custom fix for one important customer, quietly promoted to a permanent problem for everyone else.

012. Capacity Planning

The careful allocation of 100 percent of a team's available time before accounting for meetings, support, defects, dependencies, emergencies, or reality.

013. Change Management

The organizational discipline of preparing people for a change they usually discover from the new interface on Monday morning.

014. Circle Back

A polite tactic used to end a conversation you have zero intention of ever resuming.

015. Core Competency

The thing an organization is unusually good at, generally receiving less investment than the new thing mentioned during the latest executive offsite.

016. Customer-Centric

A commitment to placing customers at the center of every decision, except decisions involving deadlines, budgets, sales commitments, architecture, or executive preference.

017. Dark Pattern

Designing a user interface so intentionally confusing that canceling a subscription requires a phone call and a notary public.

018. Deep Dive

Spending two hours analyzing a microscopic edge case while the core application actively burns down.

019. Deliverable

A tangible output demonstrating progress, frequently confused with progress itself.

020. Dependency

Something another team must finish before you can finish your work, ensuring that neither team's delivery date can ever be discussed with confidence.

021. Discovery

The disciplined process of learning what should be built before building it, ideally conducted before everyone has already decided what will be built.

022. Dogfooding

Using your own product internally to experience exactly what customers experience, followed by explaining why the internal experience is somehow different.

023. Ecosystem

A collection of separate, poorly connected software products sold as a unified suite.

024. Edge Case

A user behavior considered statistically insignificant until the user experiencing it is sufficiently important.

025. Empowerment

Giving a team total autonomy to make decisions, provided those decisions align perfectly with the CEO's gut feeling.

026. Epic

A Jira ticket so vaguely defined and massive in scope that it slowly swallows three consecutive quarters of roadmap space.

027. Escalation

The formal process of adding progressively more senior people to an unresolved problem until the original problem becomes secondary.

028. ETA (Estimated Time of Arrival)

A date requested before enough information exists to provide a date, and therefore provided anyway.

029. Feature Creep

The gradual addition of individually reasonable requests until a simple application requires a flight manual.

030. Firefight

Urgent work performed to resolve an emergency while postponing the non-urgent work intended to prevent future emergencies.

031. Flywheel

A circular diagram in a presentation slide used to make a basic sales loop sound like physics.

032. Frictionless

A marketing claim applied to a checkout flow that currently requires three redirects, SMS verification, and a password reset.

033. Gap Analysis

A structured comparison between where your product is and where everyone suddenly remembers they wanted it to be.

034. Go-To-Market (GTM)

The coordinated effort by Product, Sales, Marketing, Operations, and Support to discover they each had a different launch date.

035. Governance

A collection of meetings, approvals, committees, and decision rights created to ensure important decisions are made deliberately, eventually, or elsewhere.

036. Graceful Degradation

A system's ability to fail politely while the incident channel becomes considerably less polite.

037. Greenfield

A clean slate on which to rebuild the same approval process that made the previous system impossible to change.

038. Hard Stop

A polite meeting exit tactic used to escape an unproductive call five minutes before your next unproductive call.

039. Headwinds

Conditions outside the organization's control. Frequently discovered near the end of a difficult quarter.

040. Heuristic

A practical rule of thumb used when perfect information is unavailable, later presented in PowerPoint with sufficient confidence to resemble perfect information.

041. HiPPO (Highest Paid Person's Opinion)

The ultimate decision-making framework that overrides all user research, A/B testing, and logical reasoning.

042. Impact

The measurable difference created by an initiative, usually described most enthusiastically before anyone agrees how it will be measured.

043. Incremental

Shipping in small increments, each celebrated as a major milestone until somebody asks whether the destination has changed.

044. Intake

A structured process for receiving unstructured requests from people who have already promised them to someone.

045. Iterative

Improving something through repeated cycles, assuming the second cycle survives the roadmap.

046. Jira

A system for making work visible by transforming human effort into rectangles.

047. Job To Be Done (JTBD)

A useful way of understanding what customers are actually trying to accomplish, occasionally expanded until understanding the framework becomes its own job to be done.

048. Kicking the Can

Postponing the same critical fix until its original estimate qualifies as historical documentation.

049. KPI (Key Performance Indicator)

A metric considered important enough to appear on an executive dashboard and stable enough to be redefined when necessary.

050. Lean

The elimination of waste from a process, sometimes enthusiastically extended to include staffing.

051. Legacy Code

Software everyone wants to replace, provided the replacement causes no downtime, costs nothing, and was finished last quarter.

052. Low-Hanging Fruit

Easy tasks that have been ignored for so long they are now rotting at the bottom of the backlog.

053. Market Validation

Evidence that customers actually want something, ideally obtained from customers who are neither relatives nor currently employed by the company.

054. Microservices

Dividing one application into independently deployable services, then creating a standing committee to coordinate their independence.

055. MoSCoW Method

A prioritization tool where stakeholders label 95% of items as "Must Haves" and ignore the remaining letters.

056. MVP (Minimum Viable Product)

The smallest version capable of testing a meaningful assumption, frequently interpreted as the smallest version everyone can tolerate apologizing for.

057. No-Code

Software that allows people to create applications without traditional programming, thereby moving several traditional programming problems somewhere less visible.

058. Non-Negotiable

A surprise feature request introduced at 4:30 PM on a Friday by an executive who saw a demo video on LinkedIn.

059. North Star Metric

The single measure intended to orient the organization toward long-term value, supported by approximately 47 additional measures.

060. Offboarding

A carefully documented departure process that discovers the departing employee owns half the team's automations.

061. Offsite

A meeting held somewhere expensive enough that ordinary meetings briefly feel strategic.

062. OKR (Objectives & Key Results)

A framework connecting ambitious goals to measurable outcomes, traditionally rediscovered near the end of each quarter.

063. Organic Growth

Growth achieved without marketing spend, not counting the founder personally messaging the entire internet.

064. Pain Point

A genuine customer problem that becomes progressively more dramatic as it moves closer to a sales presentation.

065. Parity

Rebuilding every mediocre feature your competitor has so users can be equally disappointed by your platform.

066. Pivot

A strategic change in direction made after new evidence emerges, or immediately before old evidence becomes impossible to ignore.

067. Post-Mortem

A structured examination of what went wrong, conducted in a psychologically safe environment where everyone already knows exactly what went wrong.

068. Proof of Concept (PoC)

A temporary experiment created solely to demonstrate feasibility and therefore naturally considered for production.

069. QBR (Quarterly Business Review)

A four-hour meeting where leaders present 80-slide decks to peers who are secretly clearing their email inboxes.

070. Quality Assurance (QA)

The systematic effort to discover whether software behaves as intended before customers perform the same research independently.

071. RACI Matrix

A matrix that assigns responsibility, accountability, consultation, and information so precisely that nobody is quite sure who can say yes.

072. Readiness

The organizational condition achieved immediately before discovering three things nobody realized were required.

073. Refactor

Improving the internal structure of software without changing its external behavior, making it simultaneously essential to engineering and nearly invisible to everyone funding it.

074. Retrospective (Retro)

A recurring meeting dedicated to identifying how the team can improve, including several improvements first identified during the previous retrospective.

075. Roadmap

A colorful visual timeline of promised features that will be completely rearranged by next Tuesday morning.

076. Scope Creep

The quiet, steady expansion of a project's requirements until a simple patch turns into a complete system rebuild.

077. Silo

An organizational boundary that functions perfectly until a customer needs two departments to solve the same problem.

078. Single Source of Truth

The authoritative location for information, alongside the spreadsheet, Slack thread, PowerPoint, Jira ticket, SharePoint page, and copy someone saved locally.

079. Spike

A time-boxed investigation intended to reduce uncertainty, occasionally concluding with a professionally documented increase in uncertainty.

080. Sprint

A fixed period for completing selected work, followed by another fixed period containing some remarkably familiar selected work.

081. Stakeholder

Anyone whose input is essential, whose priorities are urgent, and whose decision rights remain under active discussion.

082. Synergy

The predicted benefit of working together, most reliably observed in PowerPoint before the teams have met.

083. T-Shirt Sizing

Estimating complex work using clothing sizes so everyone can disagree about effort without becoming distracted by numbers.

084. Technical Debt

The future cost created by today's expedient technical decisions, making it one of the few forms of debt routinely approved without a repayment schedule.

085. Thought Leadership

The public sharing of expertise and original thinking, plus several observations about leadership that were previously available on coffee mugs.

086. Traction

Getting three sign-ups in a week and using exponential trendlines to project a billion-dollar valuation by Q4.

087. Unblock

To remove an obstacle preventing progress, commonly accomplished by scheduling a meeting with the person who did not answer the message.

088. Unicorn

A privately held startup valued above one billion dollars, proving that mythical creatures can, under certain market conditions, have capitalization tables.

089. User Story

A concise description of user value written in ordinary language before acquiring fourteen acceptance criteria and three technical dependencies.

090. UX (User Experience)

The discipline of making a product intuitive until seventeen non-negotiable requirements arrive from six departments.

091. Value Add

Extra features thrown into a contract for free because the customer threatened to switch to a competitor.

092. Value Proposition

The compelling reason customers should choose the product, polished until everyone can recite it and nobody can explain it.

093. Velocity

A measure of how much work a team completes over time, most useful until somebody decides it should become a target.

094. Water-Scrum-Fall

Quarterly commitments at the top, two-week sprints in the middle, and a release train that still waits for permission to leave the station.

095. White Paper

An authoritative industry report whose final finding is that you should enter your corporate email address.

096. WIP (Work in Progress)

A permanent state of existence for seven different features that will sit 90% complete for the next six months.

097. X-Functional (Cross-Functional)

Gathering eight people from different departments in a room to guarantee that no single person has authority to make a decision.

098. YOY (Year-Over-Year)

The growth comparison metric you switch to when your Month-Over-Month numbers look terrifying.

099. Zero-Day

A previously unknown security vulnerability for which no fix yet exists, traditionally discovered at the exact moment everyone responsible becomes unavailable.

100. Zombie Ticket

A Jira issue that was closed six months ago, only to be reopened by an angry user on a Saturday morning.